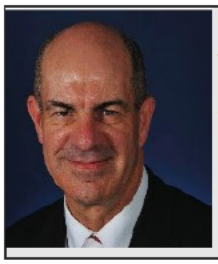
From: [redacted]
To: Committee, EM (REPS)
Cc: [redacted]"
Subject: Submission to Inquiry into the conduct of the 2025 Federal Election and related matters
Date: Friday, 17 October 2025 9:04:58 AM



The Hon. Kelvin Thomson
A: 28 Pleasant Street
Pascoe Vale, VIC, 3044
E: [redacted]

Dear Joint Standing Committee on Electoral Matters,

I wish to make a submission to your Inquiry into the 2025 Federal Election. I note that the Inquiry's Terms of Reference include the assessment and review of the purported increase in incidents of aggressive conduct, deliberate obstruction, and intimidating behaviour towards voters, political participants, volunteers and Australian Electoral Commission (AEC) officials. I am pleased that the Joint Standing Committee is looking into this, and my submission is relevant to this point.

By way of personal background, I stood for public office on 12 occasions at local, State, and Federal level, and on those occasions spent a lot of time standing on pre-poll and polling booths. I have also been involved in supporting the campaigns of other candidates at elections at which I was not a candidate, over a 50 year period from 1975 to the present. I suspect there are few Australians who have spent as much time at polling booths as I have. My first experience as a booth worker was, at the age of 20, handing out for the [redacted] Member for Wills at the time, [redacted], in the 1975 election following the dismissal of the Whitlam Government. I handed out my first ever ballot paper to a man who turned out to be the Polling Booth captain for the [redacted] Party. He tore it into 2 pieces in front of me, and threw it on the ground. So I am not starry-eyed about polling booths, or want to suggest there has ever been a golden age of polling booth conduct.

At the 2025 Federal Election I handed out How to Vote cards for the [redacted] member, [redacted] on several occasions at the Early Voting Centre in Brunswick, and at several booths on Election Day, in Pascoe Vale and Fawkner. I was shocked by the behaviour of a number of polling booth workers. Their aggressive and abusive conduct towards other polling booth workers, and their harassment of voters, was on a level I have never before witnessed. In my recollection the worst of this bullying was carried out by [redacted] polling booth workers, but other polling booth volunteers were also guilty of it.

The conduct that I witnessed on Election Day was noticeably more reasonable than that which occurred at the Early Voting Centre. The Early Voting Centre has a particular problem. It often has candidates present, as well as their most militant supporters. This is a setting

where conflict is most likely. In addition, pre-polling has become much busier in the last decade or two. The Committee will probably have access to data about this, but my impression is as follows. Years ago, people were expected to vote on the day, and you had to have a very good reason to vote early. The Electoral Commission policed this rule, and few people voted early. But in the last couple of decades of rapid population growth, queues at polling booths have grown, and the Electoral Commission has increasingly taken the view that the election is easier to manage if it is effectively spread over a period of a couple of weeks, rather than all the resources being put into Election Day. It is probably more cost effective to do things this way. As a result, the requirement to have a very good reason to vote early has been quietly let drop, and is no longer policed. Voters have become aware of this. They have decided that voting early will spare them the prospect of a long queue on Polling Day, and they have increasingly turned up at the Early Voting Centre.

Inevitably this leads to long queues at the Early Voting Centre. At the Wills Early Voting Centre, this was most unfortunate. Voters had to stand in line for long periods, while campaigners earbashed them and endeavoured to engage them in debate, following some of them as the queue slowly advanced, and asking them questions about the election and politics. It was clear to me that for the most part voters did not want to engage in debate with campaign workers, particularly when those workers were as aggressive as they were. It is also a clear breach of the spirit of the secret ballot. Normally voters entering a polling booth can choose to display their allegiance by taking only one candidate's How to Vote, or they can keep their vote secret by taking everyone's How to Vote, or no-one's. Many choose the latter course. They value the secret ballot highly. They should not be expected to respond to questions from candidates or their campaign workers. However, if they are stuck in a long queue, they are put in a very difficult position. I have no doubt that many voters who voted at Brunswick would have hated the experience. It was a poor advertisement for our democracy.

I don't have any bright ideas about how to make campaign workers behave better. However, I do think the Electoral Commission has an obligation to protect voters, and the spirit of the secret ballot, by allocating sufficient resources to polling booths, and particularly to the Early Voting Centre, to ensure that we don't have queues. That way candidates and campaign workers are restricted to a couple of words – a party slogan or whatever – as voters pass through. Voters are not obliged to listen to a diatribe, or expected to respond, when clearly most do not wish to. Some voters enjoy the opportunity to tell particular candidates what they think of them, but most do not want to become involved in conflict, and they should not be required to.

I am a fan of in person voting. Interactions between candidates and voters can add to the health of our democratic debate. But what happened at the Early Voting Centre in Wills was not that – it was a travesty which undermined public respect for our voting arrangements. I hope the Electoral Commission can act to get rid of the queues which enable such disrespectful behaviour.

Yours sincerely

Kelvin Thomson

Federal Member for Wills 1996-2016.